

Character Creation

A character in Tales Untold is defined by three stats, a deck of nine cards, and what they carry. Everything else is fiction built on top of those foundations.

Once your character exists, `rules/combat.md` covers how a fight actually works, and `rules/resolution.md` covers checks, saves, and perception outside of one.

Stats

All characters begin with:

STAT	STARTING VALUE
Body	2
Mind	2
Soul	2

Distribute **3 additional points** among these stats. No single stat may exceed 5 at character creation.

What Stats Do

Each stat owns three things: one card colour, one derived resource, and one way of solving problems.

	BODY	MIND	SOUL
Colour	Red	Blue	Green
Damage	Body + die on Red	Mind + die on Blue	Soul + die on Green
Derived	HP, weighted 4×	Hand size (minimum 2)	Initiative, 1d6 + Soul
Also governs	Physical speed and force	Reasoning and control	Reflexes
Check	Overcome a physical obstacle, impose physical control	Obtain or interpret information, solve, predict, argue	Create and hold bonds, resist spiritual pressure, enforce oaths
Save	Fatigue, falls, cold, pain, forced movement	Illusions, manipulation, memory interference	Fear, corruption, possession, despair
Perception	Senses — timing and physical signal	Reason — pattern and detail	Read — intent and weight

Maximum HP = $(4 \times \text{Body}) + \text{Mind} + \text{Soul}$. Body's share is weighted four times the other two.

Deck size = Body + Mind + Soul, and each colour's card count equals its matching stat (`rules/cards.md` , Deck Building). The same rule builds every creature in the world, so a character's deck is the same size as a creature of the same weight.

The three resources are three different currencies

That is the actual design, and it is worth understanding before you spend your three points.

- **Body buys durability.** How much you can absorb before it matters.
- **Mind buys options.** How many cards you are choosing between in each exchange.
- **Soul buys tempo.** Whether you are acting into their decision or they are acting into yours.

Body is the only stat with no cleverness in it — more damage and more HP, nothing else — which is exactly right for the colour whose whole identity is raw damage and the biggest dice.

Mind is the only one that increases the number of decisions you make. Cards are committed face down and revealed together (`rules/combat.md` , Attack Resolution), so hand size is the number of answers you get to compare before guessing. Mind 5 is not a bit better than Mind 4 at that. It is a different experience of the same fight.

Speed is Body. Reflexes are Soul.

This is the least intuitive part of the split and it is deliberate, so it is worth stating plainly.

Body is how fast you move. Ground covered, force delivered, a door taken off its hinges. When the fiction asks how quickly somebody crossed a room, that is Body.

Soul is how fast you know. Initiative is not a footrace — it is who was already moving before the thing happened.

Reflex, here, is closer to a sixth sense than to a twitch: the read, the prickle, the fact that you had turned around before you could have said why.

Yes, real reflexes are physical, and Green therefore carries the tiniest crossover into Body's territory. That is acknowledged rather than argued away. The game equates reflexes to intuition on purpose, for balance: **it keeps Body from owning both the damage ceiling and the turn order**, and it gives Soul — the stat of bonds, oaths and reading a room — something that matters in every single fight rather than only in the fights about people.

A high-Body character gets there first. A high-Soul character was already going.

The consequence that drives deckbuilding

A card's damage runs off its own colour's stat, not your best one. A Mind 5 / Body 2 character playing a Red card deals Body damage — 2 and a die. That is why colour counts match stats: it keeps every card in your deck firing at full strength.

So **one point in a stat does three things at once**: bigger damage on that colour, one more card of that colour in your deck, and HP (four of it, if it is Body). A stat is a commitment, not a slider.

Your stat spread is a statement about how your character solves problems.

Equipment

There is no limit on how much equipment a character can have. No slots, no count, no encumbrance table. Equipment comes in three kinds — **Weapon, Armor, Artifact** — and those are design and pricing categories (`rules/equipment.md`), not a ration.

The only restriction is what one person can plausibly use in concert.

That is a fiction question, asked at the table, at the moment it matters — not a number checked at creation. The useful version of it is: *could this person actually be getting the benefit of all of these, at the same time, right now?*

- **You have two hands.** A two-handed weapon is using both of them. A sword and a shield is fine; a sword, a shield and a bow is a decision about which one is in your hands when the fighting starts.
- **Armour goes on a body, and there is one of those.** You cannot wear two breastplates. A mail shirt under a coat is a conversation; a second suit over the first is not.
- **Some things need managing.** An item whose effect requires attention during a fight is competing with every other item that does.
- **Everything else is free.** Own six swords. Carry all of them. Nobody is counting.

Only what you are actually using grants its effect. A weapon on your back is on your back. Switching to it is something you do, in the fiction, and it takes whatever it would reasonably take.

Artifacts are resonant objects closely aligned with a Seat's domain (`world/resonant-items.md`). They are not ordinary equipment. They carry weight — cosmological, narrative, and mechanical. Wearing one is a statement about what you're willing to be near.

*Artifacts are the place where "use in concert" stops doing the work, because a person can wear a great deal of jewellery. The limit on them was never slots and is not supposed to be: **they are rare, they are dangerous, and they are noticed**. A character hung with three resonant items has not broken a rule. They have made themselves the most interesting thing in any room they walk into, and the world will respond accordingly.*

Carried items (potions, tools, objects picked up in the field) never needed a slot and still don't — you use them on your turn via the Use an Item action, same as any other action choice (`rules/combat.md` , Turn Structure).

Starting garb and weapon. Every character chooses what they wear and carry at creation — a sword, a bow, a walking stick, a good coat, a set of tools, whatever fits the person you made. None of it has stats and none of it has a gold value: it grants no bonus, fills no slot, and can't be sold. Nobody is going to ask you what your sword's damage is — the cards are your damage, the gear is who you are.

It still matters, constantly. Not in a fight — out of one. What you happen to be carrying is a standing answer to problems the world puts in front of you, and the GM will take it seriously:

- A sword can dig. It can pry, wedge a door, cut a rope at arm's length, and reach something you'd rather not reach with your hand.
- A bow can shoot out a light across a room you don't want to cross.
- A heavy coat is a rope, a sack, a way to carry something too hot to hold, or the reason the cold doesn't get a check out of you.

So choose it as fiction, then use it as leverage. The character who thought about what they brought will find more doors open than the one who wrote "sword" and stopped thinking about it. That is the whole design: no numbers on it, real consequences from it.

See `rules/equipment.md` for the Weapon/Armor tier system and how to design new equipment, and `rules/items.md` for the full catalog of items already in the world.

Starting Deck

Every character starts with **9 cards** drafted from the Oracle deck. *How* they get drafted is up to the table — what follows are two methods that work, not a required procedure. Any process that ends with nine cards chosen under real constraint is doing the job.

Nine is not a constant — it is your total stats. Maximum deck size equals Body + Mind + Soul, which is 9 for everyone at creation (2/2/2 plus the 3 you distributed) and moves only when a stat does. It is the same rule every creature in the world is built on (`rules/cards.md` , Deck Building), so a character's deck is the same size as a creature of the same weight.

Method One — The Shared Offer

1. The GM presents **3 random cards** from the available pool.
2. Each player takes turns choosing **1 card**.
3. Unchosen cards return to the pool.
4. Repeat, rotating pick order, until every player has **9 cards**.

Pick order alternates each round — if Player A picks first in round one, Player B picks first in round two. The pool is shared. Early picks shape what remains. A deck built alongside others is never identical to one built alone.

Method Two — The Passing Piles

1. Split the Oracle deck into **piles as equal as they'll divide**, one per player.
2. Everyone looks at their own pile and takes **1 card** from it.
3. Pass the remaining pile **to the left**.
4. Repeat until every player has **9 cards**. Whatever is left in the piles returns to the Oracle.

This one plays differently. You see a whole pile at once, which means you also see what you are handing to the person next to you — and you will watch your own pile come back around, lighter, missing the card you were hoping would

survive the trip. It rewards paying attention to what everyone else is building, and it makes denial a real option in a way the shared offer never does.

*Each pile has to survive nine passes, so this needs an Oracle of at least **9 cards per player** — the 63-card Oracle seats seven exactly, and the full 84 with the expansion seats nine. Past that the piles run dry before anyone finishes and the shared offer is the better method.*

Declaring a Price

(Price, the Second Cut.)

At the close of character creation the player speaks one binding statement beginning with *I never, I must, I always, I cannot, Once I...*, or *Whenever...*

The adherence is the Price — not the statement. Speaking the words costs nothing by itself; anyone can say a sentence. What's actually paid is everything that follows: every choice the pledge constrains, every situation where keeping it costs something real. No card is revealed at this step — there's nothing to reveal yet. The cost hasn't started accruing; it hasn't happened.

From that moment the statement is true at the table. When it is tested, the fiction treats it as binding. The player is expected to lean into it; the GM is expected to present situations that test it — the Price is being paid in exactly those moments, not at the moment of speaking.

Breaking the pledge incurs a higher cost — a curse, a forced card, a permanent mark, or another consequence the world exacts for the failure to keep what was named.

Examples

Once I have given my word before witnesses, I treat it as part of the structure of the world. Whenever I am offered a safer path that requires me to look away, I refuse it. I never abandon someone who has trusted me. I cannot refuse a direct plea made in true need. I must keep every promise I have spoken, no matter the cost. I always finish what I start, even after its purpose has eroded. I never leave a wound I have noticed unaddressed. I cannot accept help that would place me in debt. I must name what others refuse to name. I always press against any constraint or oath until I know whether it holds. I never look away from a reflection of my own past failure. Once I have claimed someone as mine, I cannot leave them behind. Whenever the edge of the Unheld is near, I move toward it. I must settle every debt I carry, whether owed by me or to me.

Hand Size

Your maximum hand size is **Mind**.

At the start of your turn, draw until you reach your hand size. If your deck is empty when you would draw, shuffle your discard pile into a new deck first, then draw.

Skills

Pick **two** at creation — either a specific trained action (Lockpicking, Negotiation, Animal Handling, and the like) or a whole Perception mode (`rules/resolution.md` , Perception).

A Skill is a literal tag on the sheet, not a card. It either plainly covers what you're attempting or it doesn't — no table judgment call the way a card's name needs one. Mechanical effect: `rules/resolution.md` , Skills.

Passives

Pick **two** at creation. Where a Skill is learned, a Passive is innate — something about what the character *is*, not something they were taught: liquid metal that reshapes into a weapon, a jaw built for a dogkin's bite. Not every character needs an exotic nature to have one, but the fiction has to actually support it — check it the same way a signature card gets checked, not granted by default.

Each Passive:

- Lives in its own zone, face up, separate from deck, hand, and discard — visible to the whole table at all times.
- Can be played as either an attack or a block. Playing one still spends your Action for the turn, the same as playing a card from hand — what's free is the resource, not the turn: no card is spent, and a Passive is never gone once used.
- Has a fixed shape, forever, chosen once at creation (or at Promotion) and never re-chosen after: one printed colour (locks the stat, same as any card — Red–Body, Green–Soul, Blue–Mind), a Range (Melee, Ranged, or Both — the fiction decides, same as any card), and a die. **d4 is the default**. A Passive that commits to Melee or Ranged only, instead of Both, can carry **d6** instead — the same trade the rest of the corpus already makes between a restriction and a bigger die.
- Carries no Effect and no Defense Effect. In their place: **Applies When**, the specific circumstance the fiction has to genuinely support for the Passive to be a legal play, this turn. A real gate, not a judgment call the way Advantage's name-check is — the same weight Range already carries. If the moment doesn't fit, the Passive isn't a worse option than a card in hand, it isn't an option at all. This is what keeps a card in hand the better choice whenever one actually fits, and keeps a card's own name a real design constraint rather than something a free fallback can always route around.
- No degradation, no growth on any of it — whatever shape it locks at creation is what it stays. A character's Stat Increases are the only thing that ever changes what it does.
- Grants Advantage on a check its printed name plausibly supports (`rules/resolution.md` , Advantage & Disadvantage) — the same judgment call a discarded card gets, except a Passive is never spent.
- Removes the effective floor a thin hand used to have. Hand and deck can both hit zero mid-fight; a Passive is always still there.

Concealment. Because a Passive's colour is fixed and printed, and the passives zone is visible to the whole table, whichever side is about to use one keeps that specific choice — which Passive, played as attack or block — concealed until simultaneous reveal, exactly like a hand card. A GM already running a screen for other reasons extends it to cover this; a table with no GM on one side (PvP) needs an equivalent for both.

Once concealment is resolved, a Passive plays exactly like any other card: `rules/combat.md`, Attack Resolution.

Passives and Traits

A Passive is a card. A Trait is a rule.

A **Passive** is the card-shaped thing described above: printed colour, Range, die, an Applies When, sitting face up in its own zone. Playing one spends your Action exactly like playing a card from hand. What it saves you is the card, never the turn.

A **Trait** is rules text that is simply true. It costs no Action, is never played, has no colour or die, and is never a choice — Armour 2, a bite that re-grants Rooted, a nose that can't be Blinded, a spirit's rolled HP. If a thing spends an Action, it is not a Trait; it is a card, and it should be written as one.

Creatures have Traits, not Passives (`bestiary/`). Every creature stat block uses that word now. The distinction matters because a creature's innate rules and a player's Passive were never the same object and shared a name for no reason: a Minotaur's Relentless has no die, no colour, and nothing to play it on.

A player character can carry a Trait too, and it doesn't cost them a Passive slot — it isn't one. Pat's Wild Magic Summoning is a Trait (`campaign/pat.md`): a line on the sheet, always true, rolling a spirit's HP when a card summons one, alongside his two actual Passives.

Passives, Skills, and Ancestry

Ancestry is where most Passives come from, and it is the only way ancestry touches the sheet. There is no ancestry table, no stat modifier, and no list of granted abilities. What a character's people does is decide what they can justify here — STRONGJAW is a dogkin's bite, ADAPTIVE CAMOUFLAGE is Glasskin skin (`factions-and-races/README.md`) — and that constraint at creation is the entire mechanic. Ancestry isn't the only source; an innate nature that isn't a people works the same way (`campaign/passives.md`, AMALGAMOUS FORM).

A Passive you can't justify becomes a Skill instead. A human with a real natural ability takes the corresponding Passive like anybody else. A human without one isn't short a resource — they take an extra Skill in its place, and a character who can justify neither Passive takes four Skills. Trained breadth is what a body that doesn't do anything unusual has instead.

The exchange is **one Skill per unjustified Passive**, so every character leaves creation holding four of something.

Nothing about this is a hard restriction list. No file says which Passives a race may take, and none should. The check is the same one every signature card gets: does the fiction actually support this, for this character, from this people. A Glasskin taking something other than ADAPTIVE CAMOUFLAGE is fine if they can support it. A human taking a Passive is fine if they can support it.

Gaining a Passive beyond your starting two: see Promotion, under Advancement, below.

The Oracle Deck

The Oracle is the living reward pool — the mechanism by which the world responds to what the party survives.

The Oracle Deck contains:

- All cards currently available as player rewards
- Unchosen cards from character creation
- Enemy signature cards recovered as loot

After each encounter, the GM may add new cards to the Oracle — ones fictionally relevant to what just happened, where the party is, or what they're becoming.

Players may also propose custom cards as the campaign develops. These enter the Oracle at GM discretion.

Magic Expression

When you play a card, you choose what it looks like.

The card tells you the mechanical outcome — the stat, the damage die, the effect. What it doesn't tell you is how your character gets there. That part is yours.

A Body card might be a punch, a shove, a weapon strike, the ground shifting underfoot. A Mind card might be a precise observation, a feint, a command that lands exactly right. A Soul card might be a ward, a breath, a moment of held stillness that changes the room.

None of it is wrong as long as it fits your character. The cards are a frame. You're the one making it mean something.

You don't have to explain the metaphysics. Neither does your character.

Advancement

End of Session The GM reveals **3 cards**; the player chooses **1** to add to their deck permanently.

Permanently yours is not the same as in your deck. Maximum deck size is your total stats (see Starting Deck, above), and a card that doesn't fit goes to your **card bank**: kept, permanent, and out of the shuffle. A long campaign doesn't thicken the deck — it deepens what's behind it.

Advancement is when the bank opens. Swap between deck and bank freely then, in either direction and as many cards as you like, as long as the deck ends at or under its maximum. Between advancements the deck is what it is.

Stat Increases Stat increases are rare and are not tied to card count. They are earned by **pivotal character development** — a moment where something in the character genuinely and permanently changes — and what qualifies is the GM's call. **They are taken at advancement**, like everything else that changes a sheet permanently: the moment earns the increase, advancement is where it lands.

These moments should feel earned, not scheduled.

A stat increase raises maximum deck size by 1, since the maximum is the stat total. Because it happens at advancement, the new slot can be filled from the bank in the same sitting.

Promotion

A card played enough, meaningfully, can become a Passive beyond your starting two — the Oracle's own way of recognizing what a character has already shown itself to be.

Nothing converts. A promoted Passive is authored fresh, in the fixed Passive shape (see Passives, above) — not a stat translation of the card that earned it. The old card's specific die, Effect, and Defense Effect don't survive; what survives is what the card meant. STRIKE promoted isn't a d4 version of STRIKE — it's a new Passive built around whatever STRIKE revealed about the character who kept playing it.

Not every card clears that bar. A card with a real fictional throughline about identity — not just a good trick — is what Promotion is for. A card that's purely a mechanical maneuver, with nothing to say about who the character *is*, doesn't become a Passive just because it got played a lot; that kind of heavy use is better rewarded another way — a Bonus Card, a Distance pick that leans into it.

The retiring card returns to the GM/Oracle pool, same as any card leaving a deck permanently.

Promotion isn't the only door. A Passive can also be granted directly, GM's call, when the fiction earns it outright — a fusion, an awakening, a bond taking hold — with no card involved at all. That's the same authority that lets a character start with a Passive at creation with no play history behind it yet; Promotion is just the version of that authority that runs through a card already in play.

Other Ways the Deck Changes

Bonus Cards — Exceptional fiction, clever play, or the right action at the right moment may occasionally earn an extra card outside the normal end-of-session reward. Rare. Entirely at GM discretion.

Permanent Removal — Cards can be permanently removed from a deck. This can be a boon (cutting a weak card to tighten what remains) or a bane (losing something valuable as a consequence). A deck that has had things removed is not diminished — it is shaped.

This is a different thing from banking a card, and the difference is whether you still own it. A banked card is out of the deck and still yours; a removed card is gone, and a card removed as a consequence does not land safely in the bank on the way out.

Curse & Status Cards — Certain encounters, locations, or narrative consequences can force cards into a player's deck. These are not chosen. They represent something the character is carrying — a wound, a debt, a mark left by the world. They may be removable. They may not be.

They sit outside the cap. A curse does not evict one of your cards to make room for itself — it goes on top, and your deck is simply larger than your stats until you are rid of it. That is the shape of the cost: the deck you built is still in there whole, diluted, and every draw is a little less likely to find it.

Equipment

Weapons, Armor, and Artifacts — the three kinds of equipment (`rules/character-creation.md`). This file covers how to design and price them. For the actual catalog of items and equipment already in the world, sorted by where they come from, see `rules/items.md` .

The Default: Dress However You Want

Fiction is unrestricted. A character can carry, wear, and wield anything the story supports — three swords, a full suit of borrowed armor, a pocket full of trinkets. None of that needs a rule.

And there is no slot limit. Weapon, Armor and Artifact are categories for designing and pricing an item, not a ration of three. **The only restriction is what one person can plausibly use in concert** — two hands, one body, and only so much attention in a fight (`rules/character-creation.md` , Equipment). That question gets asked at the table when it matters, not counted at creation.

Which moves the real limiter onto the economy, deliberately. A Tier 1 permanent is ~200 gold and a Tier 3 is ~2,000, against a world with exactly two ways to make money and a deliberately slow curve (Pacing, below). A party is not going to be wearing four Tier 3 items because nothing has paid them four Tier 3 items. **If a GM finds a character stacked with more permanents than the fight can survive, the question to ask is where the gold came from**, not which slot to take away.

Carried items (potions, tools, one-use consumables) are a separate category entirely — used via the Interact action, see `rules/items.md` for where those live.

Weapon and Armor Tiers

Weapons and Armor both scale on the same three-tier system. Each tier is a **power budget** — a fixed amount of mechanical value — spendable as a flat numeric bonus, or split across smaller effects, at the designer's discretion.

TIER	WEAPON (DEFAULT SPEND)	ARMOR (DEFAULT SPEND)	APPROXIMATE VALUE
1	+1 attack damage	Armour 1	~200 gold
2	+2 attack damage	Armour 2	~800 gold
3	+3 attack damage	Armour 3	~2,000 gold

The gold values are a reference point for pricing at market or as loot, not a hard rule — a GM can move a specific item up or down for scarcity, condition, or story reasons the same way any priced object can.

A Tier 3 item (Weapon or Armor) may instead grant +1 to a single stat — Mind, Body, or Soul — with no other bonuses attached. The entire tier's budget goes into the stat point alone; nothing gets stacked on top of it. Priced at the top tier on purpose: a stat point isn't just a bigger number, it moves other things too (Mind sets hand size 1:1, Body sets max HP, Soul sets the initiative roll), so it's worth more than any single flat bonus or keyword stack at the same tier.

The budget doesn't have to go entirely into the flat number. A tier is a total, not a minimum floor on the stat bonus — spend it instead, in whole or in part, on other effects, calibrated against the same 1-point-per-tier-level scale:

- **1 point** $\approx$ +1 flat damage or reduction, **or** granting yourself one stack of a Positive Status Effect (Deadly, Resist, Evade, etc.) at the start of combat, **or** inflicting one stack of a debuff (Weak, Blind, Staggered, etc.) on an enemy, usually gated behind "the first time you land a successful attack" or "the first time you're hit" so it triggers once per combat, not indefinitely.
- Larger, spikier effects (doubled attack damage, Immunity, a full Ward) run stronger than a single point and should either consume a whole tier on their own or come with a real restriction (once per combat, only below half HP, only on a clean win) to stay in budget.
- **Not every keyword is worth the same point regardless of context — check actual value, don't just price by name.** Protect reads like a strong defensive keyword but is genuinely one of the weakest through an action-economy lens: the party still eats the same total damage, just redirected onto whoever volunteered — no damage is actually prevented unless it's paired with something that mitigates the hit once it lands (Resist, Evade, and similar). Priced alone, it's worth well under 1 point — cheap enough to bundle in at Tier 1 alongside a real effect (e.g., start combat with Evade 1 and Protect 1) rather than ever anchoring a tier by itself. The general lesson: price a keyword by what it actually does for the action economy, not by how strong it sounds.

Worked examples, exactly as specified:

- *Tier 1 weapon:* inflicts Weak on the first successful attack against an enemy. (Whole budget spent on the debuff — no flat bonus.)
- *Tier 2 weapon:* +1 attack damage, and gain Deadly at the start of combat. (1 point flat, 1 point self-buff.)
- *Tier 2 armor:* Armour 1, and start combat with 1 Resist. (1 point flat, 1 point self-buff.)

This is a budget to design against, not a formula to solve — two tier-2 items should feel different from each other even though they cost the same.

Currency

10 copper = 1 silver. 10 silver = 1 gold.

All three are in use. Gold prices equipment, artifacts, and anything a party saves toward. Silver prices a meal, a night's lodging, pocket change in a chest. Copper prices the smallest thing anyone would still charge for.

The Gilded Tusk's menu (`places/capital/gilded-tusk.md`) shows the whole range in one place: a seasoning you add to a dish is 2 copper, ordinary mains run 6–9 silver, and the one made from something dangerous is 8 gold.

Artifacts

Artifacts don't run on the tier budget above — they're a different kind of object entirely. Per `rules/character-creation.md`: "resonant objects closely aligned with a Seat's domain... not ordinary equipment. They carry weight — cosmological, narrative, and mechanical. Wearing one is a statement about what you're willing to be near." An Artifact's mechanics should read as an extension of a specific Seat's actual domain (`world/seats.md`), not a generic stat stick reskinned — design these bespoke, one at a time, the way a signature card set gets built for a specific creature rather than pulled from a shared budget table. No standard gold value for the same reason — an Artifact's worth is cosmological before it's economic, and pricing one at market undersells what it actually is.

That's a formula's absence, not a sale's — Brother Alden does put a number on the two he carries (`items/capital-items.md`: the Quiet Index, 400 gold + a true secret archived; Cord of the Held, 250 gold + a real vow), and the shape of those two prices is the tell that nothing's actually broken: gold alone never closes the sale, there's always a second, non-gold cost standing in for what the item really is. What Alden charges to hand one over and what the Artifact costs to actually invoke (the Price, below) are two separate accountings — the second one still isn't predefined, and still emerges at the table the same as ever.

Name comes first, the same four parts as a person or a place — probably incomplete rather than closed: what something is, an actual name, traits, and history.

- **What it is.** The essential nature or function underneath the specifics — "a sword" isn't Named yet at this stage, just categorized.
- **An actual name.** The Lightning Loop, not "a ring." An Artifact earns its Name the way anything does: specificity, not a formula.
- **Traits.** What makes it recognizably itself and not another Artifact of the same rough shape — what it's exactly capable of, and what it costs to use.
- **History.** Where it came from, who made it or found it, and what it was used for before the party ever touched it.

The Price isn't a flat cost — it's an expression of what's being forced through the item. Not *"use artifact, lose 3 HP"* as a universal tax. The world permits the effect; the cost manifests in a way that answers it. Direct vitality transfer (healing someone costs the user their own vitality), physical reflection (igniting something burns the user), collateral consequence (lightning arcs to someone nearby instead of the target), loss or degradation (a memory effect costs a memory), a binding consequence (holding something in place leaves the user Anchored), a narrative one (a public miracle creates witnesses, or costs belief) — all legitimate, none of them the default. This isn't a new mechanic bolted onto Artifacts; it's the Second Cut (`world/creation-myth-the-three-cuts.md`, The Second Cut) working the way it already does everywhere else in this cosmology — nothing is exempt from Price, and what gets extracted answers the shape of what was taken, not a fixed exchange rate.

Price scales with magnitude. A minor working costs less than a major one — heal a scrape versus heal a mortal wound, spark a candle versus level a wall. The relationship isn't a lookup table, but the direction always holds: the more reality an effect bends, the more it costs to bend it.

An Archon's will can lighten or deepen that cost (`world/seats.md`) — acting in the grain of a seated Archon's nature reduces the Price, acting against it increases it. This only applies where a Seat actually has a bearer. An unheld Seat has no will to align with or defy; its Price is paid on magnitude alone.

The Price doesn't have to land entirely on whoever triggered it. An effect can cost an ally something too, without that lessening what the actor themselves still pays — the consequence propagates through whoever the working actually touched, it doesn't get divided up and handed off.

Nobody chooses their own Price, and Resonance doesn't come with an instruction manual. A wielder might know an item is dangerous from experience, tradition, or a scar that's still healing, without knowing the actual law behind it — two people can hold the same item with two different, incomplete understandings of what it costs. Skill and familiarity can shift *where or how* a Price lands, not whether it's paid or how much — that's the difference between understanding a law well enough to act inside it and having any authority over it at all.

Distance applies too, though it isn't a system this section prices. Distance is what can never be: a sword can never be a plow, a crown can never be the person who wears it. Worth asking of any Artifact worth building, the same as Name and Price are.

See `world/resonant-items.md` for what makes an object Resonant in the first place — Intentional or Accumulated — and why a Resonant Item doesn't need its Seat Filled to work at all.